reconcile the emperor with his favourite scribe.[4]

Historians have speculated that Salim discovered a chink in the armour of Abul Fazl's devotion to Akbar in the writer's conflicting loyalty to his own father.

Shaikh Mubarak may have flattered Akbar, but he was also a man of strong opinions, it seems. Badauni writes, for example, of Shaikh Mubarak giving Akbar 'a lecture on his extravagant expenditure'. On another occasion, Akbar sent all his best musicians, including Tansen, to the shaikh so that 'he might tell him what they were worth'. Shaikh Mubarak was unimpressed. 'He said to Miyan Tansin: "I have heard that you can sing a bit." At last he compared his singing to the noise of beasts, and allowed it no superiority over it.'[5]

The opinionated Shaikh Mubarak had composed a commentary on the Quran before his demise and having neglected to mention Akbar in it, had caused the emperor some offence. Now, it seems, Abul Fazl had forty clerks employed in making copies of the book – which he liked to send off to neighbouring courts – and Salim may have used this to suggest that Abul Fazl was neither as sceptical of Islam nor as faithful a disciple of Akbar's as he pretended to be.[6]

It was '[i]n consequence of . . . intrigues', at any rate, that Akbar sent Abul Fazl away, in early 1600, with the ostensible purpose of bringing Murad back home. It must have been like exile to the scribe; he had not left the emperor's side for any length of time ever since he had joined Akbar's court a quarter century ago. To make matters worse, his mission began with failure: Abul Fazl arrived at almost the very moment of the prince's death. It was not Murad he would send home, but only his remains. And yet, for all the bad blood that sent him south and all the bad luck of this beginning, Abul Fazl would run a better campaign in the Deccan than any of Akbar's sons or amirs.

The writer with no experience of military command, and so long embarrassed by the fact,[7] had a knack, it seems, for war. When he reached Murad's camp, the officers were anxious, fearing the kind of mutiny that had occurred when Munim Khan died in Bengal and imperial authority broke down. Murad had been marching towards Ahmednagar, but his men wanted to retreat. Abul Fazl, stubborn in his loyalty to Akbar's orders – 'my